

FEATURED ECOREGIONS

-  New Guinea Montane Forest »p314-19
Tropical moist broadleaf, mixed forest
-  North Australia Savannas »p320-27
Tropical grassland, scrub
-  Great Sandy-Tanami Desert »p328-33
Desert, scrub
-  East Australian Forests »p334-43
Temperate broadleaf, mixed forest
-  Great Barrier Reef »p344-53
Marine, coral reef
-  New Zealand Mixed Forest »p354-59
Temperate broadleaf, mixed forest



ARNHEM LAND

Within 930 miles (1,500 km) of the equator, this north-central region has a fiercely seasonal, monsoon tropical climate. Its intricate mix of coastal landscapes and hills harbors dozens of unique species, from rock rats to snakes. It also provides an important conservation habitat for dugongs, nesting turtles, and migratory birds.



INDIAN OCEAN

WESTERN COASTAL DESERTS

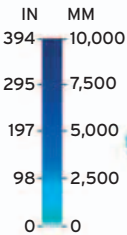
Starved from rain due to cold ocean currents and prevailing offshore winds, there is little coastal vegetation and arid conditions extend throughout.

KEY DATA

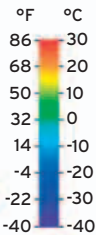
ECOSYSTEMS

-  Tropical broadleaf forest
-  Temperate broadleaf forest
-  Mediterranean woodland, scrub
-  Tropical, subtropical grassland
-  Temperate grassland
-  Desert, scrub
-  Montane grassland

AVERAGE RAINFALL



AVERAGE TEMPERATURE



SHARK BAY

The shallow, sheltered conditions in Shark Bay encourage the formation of curious concretions called stromatolites. These mounds of layered sediment with surface films of cyanobacteria are almost identical to ones that formed more than 3 billion years ago. The cyanobacteria were among the first organisms to inhabit Earth.



Timor Sea

Arafura Sea

Melville Island

Arnhem Land

Barkly Tableland

Kimberley Plateau

Great Sandy Desert

Tanami Desert

Macdonnell Ranges

A U S T R

Simpson Desert

Uluru (Ayers Rock) 867m

Lake Eyre

Gibson Desert

Great Victoria Desert

Nullarbor Plain

Lake Torrens

Kangaroo Island

Hamersley Range

Darling Range